

“Mastering Parallel Construction”

A Guide to Balanced and Clear Writing

What is Parallel Construction?

In English grammar, parallelism (also called parallel structure or parallel construction) is the repetition of the same grammatical form in two or more parts of a sentence.

WHY USE IT?

- Improves clarity
- Enhances readability
- Adds rhythm and emphasis
- Shows equal importance among ideas

FAULTY PARALLELISM

Faulty parallelism, also called faulty parallel structure, is when the list is incorrectly written—when the items are not written in the same way and don't "match."

- ❑ In the meeting, we will discuss establishing our new guidelines, how to implement the new system, and planning the holiday party. ❌
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RULES OF PARALLELISM

1. Use parallel construction when items in a series have an equal level of importance. These items are usually joined by commas or semicolons along with *and* or *or*. On the word level, a noun should be grouped with other nouns, an adjective with other adjectives, and so on.
2. When a series is composed of verbs, do not mix forms. For example, mixing an infinitive (a verb beginning with *to*) with a gerund (a verb form ending in *-ing*) breaks parallel structure.
3. Avoid mixing noun phrases with verb phrases.
4. With a series of verbs, a series of verb phrases should use parallel forms. Do not mix phrases based on an infinitive with phrases based on *-ing* verbs.
5. Parallelism is also applicable to a series of clauses in a sentence.

NOT PARALLEL

I like to jog, bake, paint, and watching movies.

The company is looking for a candidate who is friendly, organized, meticulous, and is going to arrive to work on time.

The participants in the workshop learned how to communicate, negotiate, and working collaboratively for the most effective outcome.

PARALLEL

I like to jog, bake, paint, and watch movies.

I like jogging, baking, painting, and watching movies.

The company is looking for a candidate who is friendly, organized, meticulous, and punctual.

The participants in the workshop learned how to communicate, negotiate, and work collaboratively for the most effective outcome.

NOT PARALLEL

Initial trials showed that exposure to the chemical caused memory problems, intermittent dizziness, and deters sleep.

Her main duties were answering phone calls, filing records, and to conduct visitor surveys.

He prefers movie nights at home over going to loud house parties.

PARALLEL

Initial trials showed that exposure to the chemical caused memory problems, intermittent dizziness, and insomnia.

Her main duties were answering phone calls, filing records, and conducting visitor surveys.

He prefers hosting movie nights at home over going to loud house parties.

Choose the sentence that maintains a parallel structure throughout.

- 1. Succeeding in school is all about reading closely, thinking critically, and made it to class on time. ❌
- 1. Succeeding in school is all about reading closely, to think critically, and making it to class on time. ❌
- 1. Succeeding in school is all about reading closely, thinking critically, and making it to class on time.

- The jellyfish floated in the current, it was glowing a gentle blue, and stung a diver in the rear.
- The jellyfish floated in the current, glowed a gentle blue, and stung a diver in the rear.
- ❖ Marek is a good dancer, hockey player and musician.
- ❖ Marek is a good dancer, hockey player, and he can play the violin.
- ❖ Marek is good at dancing, playing hockey and music.

Identify the error in the sentence

- ❖ The students were unprepared, poorly behaved, and disrupted the class.
- ❖ Sam is responsible for stocking merchandise, writing orders for delivery, and sales of computers.

Error: The first two items are adjectives ("unprepared", "poorly behaved"), but the third is a verb phrase ("disrupted the class").

✓ Correct:

The students were unprepared, poorly behaved, and disruptive. (all adjectives)

✗ Error: After responsible for, the first two items are gerunds ("stocking", "writing"), but the third is a noun phrase ("sales of computers").

Sam is responsible for stocking merchandise, writing orders for delivery, and selling computers.
(all gerunds)